

April 1, 2026

Dear Editor-in-Chief,

Please consider our manuscript, “Opponent-Adjusted Evaluation of NFL Pass Blocking and Pass Rushing Performance,” for publication in the *Journal of Quantitative Analysis in Sports*.

This paper develops an opponent-adjusted framework for evaluating NFL trench play at the blocker–rusher interaction level using 2021 regular-season tracking data. We construct a large interaction dataset from pass plays and fit two ridge-regularized Bradley–Terry paired-comparison models: a binary model for pass-rush wins under a 2.5-second definition and a four-class severity model over loss, win, hit, and sack outcomes. Together, these models provide interpretable player ratings for both pass blockers and pass rushers while accounting for opponent quality and double-team context.

We believe the manuscript is a strong fit for *JQAS* because it combines statistical methodology with an applied sports-analytics problem of broad interest. In addition to out-of-sample predictive evaluation, the paper includes external validation against AP All-Pro selections and produces end-of-season leaderboards that illustrate the practical value of the proposed approach. More broadly, the manuscript contributes an interpretable paired-comparison framework for player evaluation in settings where performance is sparse, role-dependent, and shaped by opponent strength.

This manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and has been approved by all authors. The co-authors have authorized the corresponding author to act on their behalf for submission and correspondence with the journal.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Jonathan Pipping-Gamón
on behalf of all co-authors
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